for a proper democratic system. This not only results in little or no support for the state structures across the broader population – it also results in less political participation since no one believes that involvement in politics can really change things.[23]

In 2015, six years after our research had started, attitudes had not changed significantly. Alienation and anger ran high when young people spoke about the state: '*The government needs to get its priorities right. We don't need roads, [we] need to solve more the energy and unemployment crisis*' (Focus Group, Private University[24]). Some did not even recognize the state: '*We are not aware of things like the state*' (Focus Group, Private University[25]), while for others it was a '*symbol of strength*' yet '*not fulfilling its role*' (Academic, Female, Faisalabad[26]). Most young people across Pakistan had little or no understanding of the nature of the state. In explaining the definition of a state, some linked it to Islam: '*Islam ka kila aur uska mustakbil*'[27] (Focus Group, Government University[28]); '*Aik Islami Riyaasat hai jo keh ab barai naaam hee islami hai*'[29] (Focus Group, Government University[30]); '*Popularly: "To provide a homeland for Muslims of India and to help establish Islam in the world*"' (Focus Group, Private University[31]). Most confused the roles of the state, the government, political parties, and the army: '*I doubt we really have a state now. It's just political parties and the army taking turns at playing king*' (Focus Group, Private University[32]); '*Pakistan state is just the training ground for the army*' (Student, Male, Karachi[33]). Given the role of the military in Pakistani politics and the running of the state, in particular its direct influence on foreign relations and internal security, such conflation between the state and the military only highlights the nature of the 'security' state in Pakistan.

Consequently, there is no confidence in public institutions. However, for the social contract to work, institution building and trust in institutions is key. Yusuf in his work (2011) highlights the lack of young Pakistanis' confidence in public institutions; 60 per cent have confidence in the army, 40 per cent in religious institutions and less than 10 per cent in the national government. 'Perhaps the most alarming is how averse Pakistani youth are to direct political activity' (Yusuf 2011, p. 266). This is despite the creation of a youth parliament in 2007.[34] The engagement of political parties with young people in the run-up to the 2013 elections was largely superficial despite political rhetoric around jobs, education and inflation. Only the PTI and the PML(N) promised seats to young people in their programmes[35] (Jinnah Institute 2013).

In-depth research[36] conducted by the British Council (BC) about how the young generation felt about the 2013 elections found that on aggregate young people in Pakistan were very pessimistic. The main issues remained